

What's neat about these live tiles is that they can provide rich notification information, allowing you to discover, at a glance, what's going on without having to manually navigate to the underlying application. Consider something basic like the calendar. On the iPhone, the Calendar icon, like any other iPhone icon, can provide only textual notifications. So you can glance at that icon and see that you have one or two pending items in your schedule, but to find out more you have to launch the application. On Windows Phone, the Calendar tile comes alive with information about your next pending schedule item. There's no need to dive into the application. You can just glance and go. These rich

notifications can work on any live tile. The People tile animates with each contact's picture. The Pictures tile which spans across the width of the screen, occupying twice the space of lesser tiles will show photos stored on the device as well as those from various online services. The Xbox Live tile displays your avatar. And so on. Third parties, too, can create their own customised live tiles.

Windows Phone also offers a second start experience. This one will be more familiar to those of you with experience with other smart phones, because it presents a simple list of every single application installed on the device. Where the default Start screen is "glance and go," this secondary screen accessed by tapping the small arrow icon on the right side of the start screen is "get me there." Here, you'll find a scrollable list, similar to what was available previously in Windows Mobile 6.5 but formatted a bit differently, of every single app on the device. We will be discussing the Start screen and live tiles in more detail later in this chapter.

While some power users may prefer to swap out the Start screen for the more static apps list as the default UI, there is no way to do so. But even if there was, a caution against doing so: The visual, live tile-based Start screen is, one of Windows Phone's strongest selling points and is both useful and attractive.



The Start screen